

Long Way HOME



SONIA'S SINGLE-MINDED PURSUIT SAW THE BILL CLEAR THE RAJYA SABHA

With the Women's Bill, the Congress seems to have empowered itself with the new credo of heading a Government that delivers

| By Priya Sahgal |

It was only the first step in the legislative process to reserve a chunk of seats for women in Parliament and assemblies, but for the Congress and particularly its President Sonia Gandhi, it was a giant leap for womankind. After 14 years of hedging and huffing, the historic, if controversial, Constitution (108th Amendment) Bill that grants 33 per cent reservation to women was passed by the Rajya Sabha on March 9.

What is equally path-breaking is the cross-party support the bill drew, with the BJP and the Left joining hands with the UPA to support it. A euphoric Sonia, who had been watching the proceedings live on TV with her fingers crossed, broke from protocol, stepped into media glare and said that she was "particularly happy". She has reason to celebrate. She single-handedly brought the Left and Right together to deliver gender empowerment and, more importantly, a key component of the Congress manifesto.

Of course, the Congress has in the bargain lost the support of some of its secular allies. RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav and Samajwadi Party President Mulayam Singh Yadav have both announced that they will withdraw "outside support" of their 26 MPs to the UPA. More serious is the threat from the mercurial Mamata Banerjee who suddenly decided to boycott the bill at the last minute. To pass the bill in the Lok Sabha, the

By doggedly pursuing the reservation bill against all ODDS, THE CONGRESS has achieved the moral high ground.